Agartala, Itanagar, Imphal and Kohima are so far away from the heat and dust of Delhi that elections in the Northeast have too often been seen by the capital's political and intellectual elites as footnotes to the larger story, at best—or ignored, at worst. The big tectonic shift between 2016 and 2019 saw the lifting of these self-limiting blinkers. In that sense, the planting of the saffron flag in Guwahati, Agartala, Imphal, Itanagar, Kohima and Shillong is not only a historic advance for the BJP, but also a significant shift of registers for India's polity.

These victories also signify three big political messages. For one, they legitimately allowed the BJP to claim that it was more than a Hindi–Hindu party and was thus the national inheritor of the Congress's traditional mantle as the only pan-Indian party. The party can assert this claim because many north-eastern states have a very high proportion of religious minorities. BJP-ruled Assam has the highest proportion of Muslims in any large Indian state after Kashmir: 34.2 per cent of its people profess Islam (only Lakshadweep has more—96.5 per cent Muslims—but in a population of only 64,473).[17] Several north-eastern states where the BJP won power have a very high density of Christian populations. As much as 87.9 per cent of Nagaland, 74.5 per cent of Meghalaya, 41.2 per cent of Manipur and 30.2 per cent of Arunachal Pradesh is Christian.[18] For a party accused of being majoritarian and Hindu-centric, the symbolism of victories in these states was huge. This is why, on the day the party won victories in Tripura, Nagaland and Meghalaya in March 2018, Amit Shah declared: 'Our victory in the Northeast shows that the taunt about us, especially among you in the media, that the BJP is not an all-India [Akhil Bharatiya] party, has been proved wrong. We now have an MP in Ladakh. We rule in Kohima and we rule also in Kutch. The Northeast victories have brought the real all-India character of the BJP in front of the whole world.'[19] The political message was not lost on the Opposition either. As the Congress's former Assam chief minister Tarun Gogoi said, 'They want it all. They want to show that they are an all-India party.'[20]

Significantly, the BJP's advances in the Northeast also signalled a retreat of the Congress in states it had dominated for decades. The Congress was literally reduced to zero seats in Tripura and